

Commonwealth, state and territory fishery ministers met virtually today, for the first time since 2019.

Ministers acknowledged the importance of the fishing and seafood sector to both the economy and the Australian community.

Minister Watt announced the release of the Australian Government Aquaculture Statement and Ministers agreed to review the National Aquaculture Strategy 2017, with work to be led by officials through the Australian Fisheries Management Forum.

Ministers discussed the following issues:

- Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated (IUU) fishing
- Opportunities to boost First Nations engagement in fisheries
- Addressing the shared challenges of climate change, sustainability, and increasing competition in the marine estate
- Opportunities for collaboration on recreational fishing initiatives.

Ministers acknowledged the increased resourcing by commonwealth, state and territory governments to tackle IUU fishing and noted the increasing numbers of vessels being intercepted and destroyed.

Ministers recognised the importance of economic opportunities for First Nations Australians in the seafood sector. Economic development opportunities, greater self-determination, partnerships and participation in decision-making will help support thriving Indigenous fishing communities and contribute to priorities and goals under the National Agreement on Closing the Gap. Ministers requested the Australian Fisheries Management Forum to explore opportunities for greater First Nations engagement in the fisheries sector.

Ministers agreed to work together to consider how to address issues such as climate change, sustainability, and access to sustainable seafood. The Futures of Seafood project, led by Seafood Industry Australia, alongside Blue Economy CRC, will provide governments with a clearer picture of the impacts of emerging marine activities and climate change pressures on fishing and aquaculture, informing planning and helping to identify potential future opportunities for the sector to grow.

Ministers noted the important pastime of recreational fishing in Australia and the significant contribution recreational fishing makes to the economy and to the personal wellbeing of its participants. Ministers agreed to continue to collaborate to support sustainable, high quality recreational opportunities across Australia.

Ministers supported the decisions of the Agriculture Ministers' Meeting, held in March 2024, in relation to progressing the development of a proposal for a trial controlled release of the carp virus as a biological control agent for common carp. This will occur in parallel to the priority actions identified in the National Carp Control Plan to ensure trials are ready to be undertaken following regulatory approvals.

Following recent outbreaks of white spot disease in New South Wales and Queensland, Ministers noted the need for a national collaborative approach through an increased focus by the National Biosecurity

Committee.

Ministers recognised shark depredation is an issue affecting commercial and recreational fishers in Australia and noted current research will help inform possible mitigation strategies.

Ministers agreed to meet again later this year.

## **Ministerial attendees**

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Minister for Emergency Management
- New South Wales: The Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Regional New South Wales, Minister for Western New South Wales
- Northern Territory: The Hon Mark Monaghan MLA, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries, Minister for Education, Minister for Mining
- Queensland: The Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agriculture Industry Development and Fisheries, Minister for Rural Communities
- South Australia: The Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Regional Development, Minister for Forest Industries
- Tasmania: The Hon Eric Abetz, Minister for Business, Industry and Resources, Minister for Transport, Leader of the House
- Victoria: Steve Dimopoulos, Minister for Tourism, Sport and Major Events, Minister for Environment, Minister for Outdoor Recreation
- Western Australia: The Hon Don Punch MLA, Minister for Fisheries, Regional Development, Disability Services, Seniors and Ageing, Volunteering

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/fisheries-ministers-meeting-june-2024>